

4.1

Giving and asking for opinions

Worksheet

A You don't need any special phrases to give an opinion. However, using a few opening words will:

- show other people that you want to start speaking (useful in a formal meeting)
- give you a few seconds 'thinking time' to decide what you are going to say
- show how strongly you feel

May I come in here? Basically, ... I reckon ... I wonder if I could say something?
Actually, ... Well, from my point of view ... Wait a minute, ... Don't you think that ...?

Write the phrases in the box in the appropriate column below.

**Informal, direct language – for example
in a discussion between two people**

*The point is ...
Frankly, ...*

**Formal, careful language – for example
in a meeting with several people**

*I tend to feel that ...
It seems to me that ...*

B After giving your own opinion you need to ask other people for their opinions and keep the discussion moving. Write the phrases in the box in the appropriate column below.

What about you, Li? What's your reaction to that, Luca?
Walter? Would you like to add anything, Ginta?

An informal discussion

What do you think, Harumi?

A formal meeting

How do you feel about that, Pedro?

C Do the following:

- 1 Work in pairs. Choose a topic from the 'General' list, and have an informal, direct discussion.
- 2 Then form a larger group, choose a topic from the 'Business' list, and have a more formal, careful meeting to discuss the topic.

General

Violence on television
The future of China (or Russia)
Cars in cities
Traveling abroad
A current general news item

Business

Doing business on the Internet
Recruitment and selection techniques
The impact of globalization
Management: the latest ideas
A current business news item

D Discuss:

- Did you notice any language differences between the discussion and the meeting?
- What language did you need?



4.2a

Developing an argument

Business Builder
Teacher Resource Series

Worksheet

A Study the underlined words in examples 1–8.

- 1 French food is very good. In fact, many people think it's the best in the world.
- 2 Spanish food has some excellent dishes. For instance, paella is famous all over the world.
- 3 Italian food tastes delicious. What's more, it's cheap and easy to prepare.
- 4 Mexican food is becoming more and more popular. However, some people find it a little too hot.
- 5 Japanese food is varied, healthy and tastes good. In a word, it's excellent.
- 6 On the whole I like Thai cooking very much.
- 7 The food in Portugal is very good. At least, you can usually eat well near the coast.
- 8 English people want healthier diets. Therefore, the food is slowly getting better.

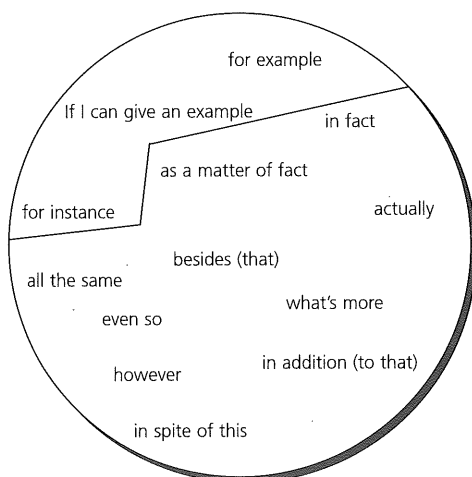
Now match the examples above with the definitions below. Two have been done for you

- | | |
|--|-------------------------------------|
| a Explaining by giving an example _____ | e Defining more exactly _____ |
| b Giving real/true/surprising information <u>1</u> | f Giving a result/consequence _____ |
| c Making a contrast _____ | g Talking generally _____ |
| d Adding another, different idea _____ | h Summarizing <u>5</u> |

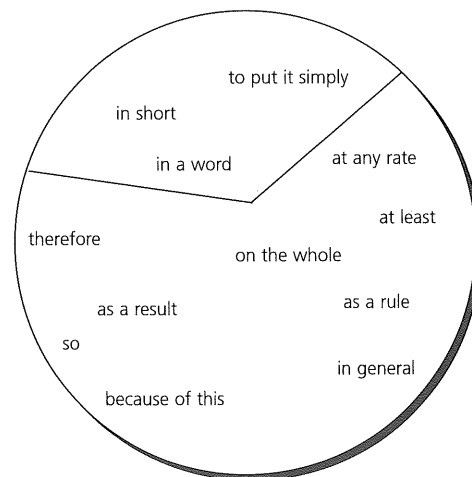
B Divide these words into four groups by drawing lines. The first group has been done for you. If you are not sure, try using the words in the examples above, to see if they sound right.

Divide these words into four groups by drawing lines. The first group has been done for you. If you are not sure, try using the words in the examples above, to see if they sound right.

Explaining by giving an example



Summarizing



Now write each definition a–h from section A next to the correct group. Two have been done for you.



4.2b

Developing an argument

Worksheet

- C** Study this text about smoking. Fill in the gaps using words from the diagram on the left in section B. There may be more than one possibility so look carefully at the whole text to see which words are best.

In general, I am a tolerant person. (1) _____, in the case of smoking I think there should be more controls. (2) _____, I believe that it should be stopped completely. I know that smoking gives people pleasure and it's difficult to give up, but it does affect me as a non-smoker. (3) _____, I have to pay extra for the health service with my taxes. (4) _____, I can never find a smoke-free bar – they just don't seem to exist.

Now study this text about education. Fill in the gaps using words from the diagram on the right in section B. There may be more than one possibility so look carefully at the whole text to see which words are best.

(5) _____ it seems that primary schools do a good job in most countries. But at high school level the problems start. (6) _____ that's the case in the U.S. and Britain. Maybe education could be improved if schools had to compete for customers in a free market. The good ones would grow and the bad ones would close. They would receive money from the state according to how many 'customers' (students) they could get. (7) _____, schools would be privatized. This system is not popular with teachers and (8) _____ it hasn't really been tried. But it could be the trend for the future.

- When you have checked your answers read both texts aloud. Try to feel how the speaker is developing the argument.
- Now read again, this time substituting different words from the same groups in section B.

- D** Work in small groups. Choose one of these topics then discuss it. As you speak, try to use some of the language from section B.

- Should smoking be restricted, or is it a freedom? And what about controls on these 'freedoms': owning guns; drinking and driving; owning dangerous dogs to guard houses?
- Is there a trend in your country for high schools (secondary schools) to be 'privatized'? Would the changes suggested in the text lead to chaos? Would children from poor areas have a choice? What other changes are happening in your education system?

- E** Choose a topic from the lists, or one of your own. Write a short dialogue between two people discussing the topic. Remember to include phrases from section B.

General

UFOs
New buildings in historic city centers
Will American culture become world culture?
A new leisure technology
Job mobility, unemployment and families
Save the tiger! Save the panda! Why?
Surviving on a desert island
A current news item

Business

The latest trends in marketing
Privatization
Dealing with a complaint
Choosing the right supplier
Collecting money from slow payers
Business and the environment
The latest trends in financial services
A current news item

4.3

Agreeing and disagreeing

Worksheet

- A** 'I think Italian food is fantastic.' Complete the table below using phrases from the box.

Yes, you're right. Isn't it a little difficult to prepare? Yes, it's marvellous.
I don't really agree with you. Do you? Especially pizzas.

Agreeing

- 1 Using a 'standard phrase' for agreeing on any topic _____
- 2 Using another word that means the same (a synonym) _____
- 3 Making a general comment *Yes, all Mediterranean food is.* _____
- 4 Giving an example _____

Disagreeing

- 5 Using a 'standard phrase' for disagreeing on any topic _____
- 6 Yes, but ... *Maybe, but Thai food is better.* _____
- 7 Asking an open question _____
- 8 Asking a negative question _____

- B** Below are more responses to the comment about Italian food. Write the appropriate technique number 1–8 from section A next to each response. The first one has been done for you.

- a Well, it's OK, but I don't think it's as good as our food. 6
- b Me too. I love Italian ice-cream. _____ and _____
- c Yes, it's absolutely delicious. _____
- d Really? Do you think so? _____
- e Yes it is, isn't it. _____
- f I'm not sure I agree with you. It's all just tomatoes and herbs, isn't it? _____ and _____
- g Yes, but I prefer French myself. It's more varied. _____
- h Yes, I agree. It's one of the best in the world. _____ and _____

- C** First agree then disagree with these six opinions. Write your responses. Use techniques from section A and your own ideas.

- 1 Cold in here, isn't it?
- 2 This wine is very good.
- 3 My Volkswagen is very reliable.
- 4 I think we should cancel the whole project right now.
- 5 I think SuperAudit should audit our accounts next year.
- 6 I think we should move production to a country where labour costs are cheaper.

- D** Write an opinion about a topic of your choice. Choose something of general interest that will create a lively discussion.

I think _____

Form small groups. Read out your opinion and continue the discussion. Remember to ask other people for their opinion (*What about you? What do you think, Hans?*)

4.4

Developing a complex argument

Worksheet

- A** Study this extract from a talk about tourism. Are any of the problems the same for your country?

Well, in this country we are facing two main problems: firstly the fact that our tourism industry is based on just one main product, that is to say 'sun and sand' type holidays, and secondly the fact that the tourists who come here don't spend very much money. It's true that our economy has benefited from tourism, but on the other hand I'm sure you'll agree that we've had too much poor quality construction and too little attention to planning. We must learn from these mistakes, otherwise we will destroy our few remaining natural areas.

As regards the problem of low spending by our visitors, the only solution is to improve the product we offer. Unless we do this, we won't survive in the future. Other countries now offer beach holidays at cheaper prices than ours. So we have to look for new markets, both in terms of the type of customer we attract and the geographical regions they visit.

As far as developing new regions is concerned, we need to support tourism in the interior of the country, particularly 'cultural tourism'. To start with, we urgently need to restore many old churches, castles and other historic buildings, and then we also need to market the attractions of these rural areas more actively.

On the whole I'm reasonably optimistic about the future of our industry, but it's going to become more and more important to pay attention to customer service. In particular we must give more training to employees in the hotel and restaurant sectors.

- B** Complete the table with the underlined phrases from section A. Remember that most phrases have two parts.

Listing more than one point	For one thing, ... and for another, ...
	1 _____ 2 _____
Giving both sides of an argument	In general ..., although ...
	3 _____ 4 _____
Saying what will happen in certain circumstances	If we ..., it'll probably mean that ...
	5 _____ 6 _____
Introducing another point	In relation to ...
	7 _____ 8 _____

- C** Write the script for a short talk on the future of the tourist industry in your city or country. Use phrases from section B. Then work in small groups: read out your scripts and develop a discussion.



4.5

Making suggestions

A Underline the phrases used for making suggestions in examples 1–4 below.

- 1 Shall we postpone the launch of the new product until the spring?
- 2 Can I make a suggestion? Why don't we try a poster campaign on bus stops?
- 3 It's just an idea, but what about using an outside company to recruit and select our senior managers?
- 4 Let's go back for a moment, if that's OK. Perhaps we should rethink the whole project?

Match the beginnings and endings below to make replies used for *accepting* a suggestion.

- | | |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------|
| 5 OK, let's ... | ... worth trying. |
| 6 Yes, I think that would ... | ... do that. |
| 7 Yes, that might be ... | ... what you mean. |
| 8 Right. I can see ... | ... work really well. |

Now do the same for these replies used for *rejecting* a suggestion.

- | | |
|--|--------------------------------|
| 9 I can see one or two ... | ... about that, to be honest. |
| 10 That sounds like a good idea, but I ... | ... think so? |
| 11 I'm not really sure ... | ... don't think it would work. |
| 12 Do you ... | ... problems with that idea. |

B Work with a partner. Student A read out each suggestion 1–4 above. Student B cover the second half of the replies 5–12 with a piece of paper and reply by accepting or rejecting. Change roles and repeat when you finish.

C The rejecting phrases above are all quite diplomatic. Below is a stronger phrase. Add one more.
I'm sorry, I don't think that's a good idea. _____

D Work with a new partner. Student A make suggestions (invent your own ideas). Student B reply by accepting or rejecting. If you reject the suggestion, add a reason.

E Work in small groups. Choose one of the problems below. Make suggestions and decide on the best solution. At the end tell the class what you decided.

- 1 You live in a country with a lot of rainforest. Your company is a timber company (you cut down trees and export the wood). You contribute to the development of your country by providing jobs and paying taxes. Environmental groups are trying to restrict your activities.
- 2 You work for a Sunday newspaper which is second in the market. Your newspaper is a good product, but the market leader has just cut their price and started a very aggressive advertising campaign. You need to think of a loyalty scheme to keep your readers.
- 3 One of your main customers has not paid their last three invoices. They now owe you \$100,000. You have already sent a polite letter asking them to pay as soon as possible. They are a large company and you don't want to lose their business.
- 4 One of you (decide who) has just inherited \$20,000 from a rich aunt. Suggest how to invest the money for long-term growth.



4.6

Checking understanding

Worksheet

A Read part of a conversation between two people discussing working from home.

- A:** I used to work from home while my children were young, but I didn't really like it.
B: I don't understand. What didn't you like? I've always wanted to work from home.
A: Perhaps I didn't explain very well. Let me put it another way. I suppose I missed the teamwork, having other people to discuss ideas with.
B: So in other words you felt isolated and missed the social contact. Is that right?
A: Yes, exactly.
B: I'd be happy to spend more time working at home. I'm tired of all the office politics at Finance International. And I hate my journey to work every morning.
A: What do you mean? I thought you had a good relationship with your colleagues. Do you want to change jobs?
B: No, sorry, that's not really what I meant. In fact I love my work. But I'd like the chance to do a bit more work from home.
A: So are you saying you want more variety and more control over your time?
B: Yes, I suppose so.

Underline phrases used for checking understanding and clarifying in the dialogue above.

Work in small groups. Discuss your ideas on working from home. Check that you understand exactly what other people mean using phrases from the dialogue and your own questions.

B Match the beginnings and endings of these phrases.

- | | | |
|-------|--|--------------------------------|
| _____ | { 1 Sorry, could you say ... | ... you say 'office politics'. |
| _____ | { 2 I'm sorry, I didn't ... | ... that again please? |
| _____ | { 3 I don't understand what you mean when ... | ... catch that. |
| _____ | { 4 Could you be a little ... | ... more specific? |
| _____ | { 5 So, in other words, you felt isolated. Is ... | ... that right? |
| _____ | { 6 Are you ... | ... put it another way. |
| _____ | { 7 Perhaps I didn't explain very well. Let me ... | ... what I meant. |
| _____ | { 8 No, sorry, that's not really ... | ... saying ...? |

Write the headings in the box on the appropriate lines above.

Using your own words to check Asking for repetition
Asking for more information Replying: apologizing then clarifying

C Work in small groups. Each person in turn choose a topic from the list (or one of your own) and discuss it with your group. Check understanding very carefully. When you finish you will have to explain to a new partner what your colleagues said.

- A complex project I once worked on.
- A complex process in my factory/office.
- The election system in my country.
- One thing in my national culture I am proud of, and one I am not proud of.



4.7

Diplomatic language

- A** Practise speaking these pairs of sentences. Say the sentences on the left in a strong, direct way. Say the sentences on the right in a diplomatic way: speak more slowly, use pauses and start questions with a higher voice.

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1 <u>Can</u> I go back to the point about timing? | <u>Could</u> I <u>just</u> go back to the point about timing? |
| 2 It's <u>very hot</u> in here. | It's <u>a bit hot</u> in here, <u>isn't it</u> ? |
| 3 We have a problem. | It seems we have a slight problem. |
| 4 There'll be a delay. | There might be a small delay. |
| 5 Can I interrupt for a moment? | Could I just interrupt for a moment? |
| 6 That'll be very expensive | That might be quite expensive. |
| 7 That'll be very expensive. | Won't that be a bit expensive? |
| 8 Can we meet again next week? | Perhaps we could meet again next week? |

- What are the advantages and disadvantages of using direct language?
- In which business situations would you expect to hear diplomatic language?

- B** Complete the table below with the sentence numbers from section A. The first two sentence numbers have been done for you.

a can ► could

1

b will ► might

c perhaps/maybe

d just

e seems/appears

f negative question

g a small/a slight (+ noun)

h a bit/quite (+ adjective)

- C** Rewrite these phrases so that they are more diplomatic. Use techniques from section B and your own ideas. Practise speaking your new phrases.

- | | |
|--|-------|
| 1 I want to make a change to the agenda. | _____ |
| 2 It'll be better to ship the goods via Singapore. | _____ |
| 3 We have a problem with our assembly line. | _____ |
| 4 That will be difficult. | _____ |
| 5 Can I finish what I was saying? | _____ |
| 6 Your estimate for the total cost is too low. | _____ |
| 7 That's very strange. | _____ |
| 8 The project is running late. | _____ |

- D** One person in each situation below will use diplomatic language. Act out the situations with a partner.

- 1 You are at the reception desk of a big company and want to see the President for a few minutes.
- 2 You have to tell a customer that there will be a delay of 4 weeks with the goods.
- 3 You are talking to a journalist who wants to write a story about your company's latest (bad) profit figures.
- 4 You are talking to a customer who is complaining about the bad service of your company. Decide before you begin what the complaint is about.

4.8

Chairing: opening the meeting

Worksheet

A At the beginning of a meeting the chairperson has a lot to do. Put these tasks in a likely order. One has been done for you.

- | | | |
|---|---|-------------------------------------|
| a | Asking somebody to introduce the first item | 1 |
| b | Welcoming and thanking everybody | 2 |
| c | Explaining the objectives of the meeting | 3 <i>Introducing new colleagues</i> |
| d | Introducing new colleagues | 4 |
| e | Getting everybody's attention | 5 |
| f | Looking at the agenda | 6 |

B Complete the table with words from the box.

Right purpose get through item agenda background
say a few words at such short notice facing distribute

Getting attention	(1) _____, is everybody here? Good, I think we can start.
Welcoming and thanking	Well, good morning everyone. Do you all have a copy of the (2) _____? I'd like to thank you all for being here (3) _____
Introducing new colleagues	First of all, I'd like to introduce Hiroshi from our Tokyo office. Would you like to (4) _____ about yourself, Hiroshi?
Explaining the objectives	The main (5) _____ of this meeting is to ... The problem we're (6) _____ is that ...
Looking at the agenda	You can see from the agenda that we have a lot to (7) _____. I've prepared some figures to help us compare the two options. I'll (8) _____ them now.
Asking somebody to start	Okay, let's move straight to the first (9) _____. Kim, would you like to kick off? Ana, would you like to begin by explaining the (10) _____?

C Write the opening comments for a real meeting that you are going to have (or recently had) in your job. Use real names and real agenda items. Consider these points:

- Do you have to introduce anybody?
- Do you have to mention any 'housekeeping' points like arrangements for coffee, the finish time, where the bathroom is etc.?
- Do you need to explain the objectives of the meeting?
- Do you need to explain the procedure of the meeting (the structure, who will speak etc.)?
- Do you have to review any tasks done since the previous meeting?
- Do you need to give any background information?
- How are you going to move into the first item?

Practise your opening comments. Start by reading them, then try without using your notes.

4.9a

Chairing: managing the discussion

Worksheet

A Jurgen is not speaking in the meeting, although the topic is relevant to him. Which of these comments do you think would encourage him to speak, and which would not?

- 1 Jurgen, you've been very quiet. What do you think?
- 2 Jurgen, after we've heard from Rosa can we have your views? I know you have some experience of this problem.
- 3 I think that's an excellent idea. What do you think, Jurgen?
- 4 Your opinion would be valuable, Jurgen. How do you feel about this?

B The table below shows techniques that a chairperson can use to manage the discussion. Complete the table with words from the box.

So consider reaction to view on mean by Are you saying in favour
go over go round the table a little more specific to approach this against

Asking for opinions	What's your (1) _____ that, Carlos? What's your (2) _____ this, Neela?
Asking for clarification	I don't understand. Can you be (3) _____ ? I'm sorry, what do you (4) _____ 'a small problem'?
Using your own words to check	Let me see if I understand. (5) _____ ... ? Sorry, do you mean that ... ?
Summarizing	(6) _____, can I just summarize what we've discussed so far? John, can we just (7) _____ your objections again?
Widening the discussion	Is there anything else we should (8) _____ ? What other ways are there (9) _____ ?
Checking everyone agrees	Does everyone agree that we ... ? Can we (10) _____ to see if everyone agrees? All those (11) _____ ? And all those (12) _____ ?

C Look at these six situations. You are the chairperson. Think of a question you could use to manage the discussion in each case. Write your answers using phrases from section B.

- 1 Lee has mentioned 'process reengineering' and one or two people look confused.

- 2 Pamela has suggested that the new product is launched in July. You are not sure if everyone agrees.

- 3 The discussion is going well, but Olga hasn't said anything. The topic is relevant to her.

- 4 There seems to be agreement among the people who have spoken, but you think there may be other ideas.

- 5 There has been a long discussion about possible problems in the manufacturing process.

- 6 Mike is explaining that your main customer is having serious financial difficulties.

4.9b

Chairing: managing the discussion

Worksheet

D Choose three students then practise this short dialogue from the middle of a meeting:

- Chairperson:** So, Hilary, you're going to prepare a short report. Can you circulate it before the next meeting? Thanks. Now, shall we turn to the question of the advertising campaign?
- Student B:** Sorry for interrupting, but I'd just like to go back for a moment to item three on the agenda. Did we decide to have soup or orange juice in the drinks machine?
- Chairperson:** Soup, I think, but coming back to what I was saying, we need to discuss next year's advertising campaign.
- Student C:** Can I just come in here? It seems to me that we made a very bad decision in relation to the drinks machine.
- Chairperson:** I think this is a bit of a side-track. I thought we finished that agenda item. Can we get back to the main point?
- Student C:** Sorry, can I just finish? I'm absolutely certain that most of our visitors prefer orange juice to soup.
- Chairperson:** Right. We'll have orange juice then. Now, can we move on to discuss the advertising campaign please? Who would like to begin?
- Student B:** Well, in my opinion we should use posters all over the metro ...
- Student C:** No, no, no, it's much better to use magazines.
- Chairperson:** One at a time, please. First (Student B), then (Student C).

E Complete the table with the underlined phrases from section D.

Letting one person speak	Can we start with Sergei?
	1 _____
Trying to return to the main point	Perhaps we should leave that until the next meeting?
	2 _____
	3 _____
Changing to a new topic	Well, I think that covers everything on that point.
	4 _____
	5 _____

- Which single word in the dialogue is used for summarizing? _____
- Which single word in the dialogue is used for taking control of the discussion? _____

F Have a short meeting to discuss the social program for your group. Study the agenda and your role notes before you begin.

Agenda

- 1 Group lunch: which day? where?
- 2 Social or cultural trip next weekend: where? arrangements?

Participants Take part in the meeting in a serious, helpful way. However, each person also has a topic not relevant to anyone else that he/she wants to discuss (decide what it is before you start). Try, without being too rude, to direct the conversation towards your topic.

Chairperson Chair the meeting. Try to focus the discussion on the main points and avoid side-tracks. After some time let another student practise chairing the meeting.

At this point I'm going to hand over the chair to ...

4.10

Topics for discussion

List 1

Computer games and children
Fast food: convenience or rubbish?
Traveling abroad: what I like/dislike most
Stress at work: how to beat it
Doing business on the Internet
Genetic Engineering: where are the limits?
Single child: advantage or disadvantage?
The most beautiful city in the world is ...
The case for greater regional independence in my country
A place to live: city, suburbs or country?
The transport problem in my city
The best food in the world comes from ...
Protect the rain forests! But America and Europe cut down their forests on the road to development.
Where is the audience for intelligent television programmes?
The world economy in five years' time
Space exploration: is the expense justified?
Emotional intelligence
UFOs
Festivals in my country

List 2

The best restaurant in this city
Working from home
The best film/play/musical I've seen recently
Latest trends in financial services
What future for Russia?
Rock music: is it political?
Football: why is it the world's most popular sport?
Management experts: over-paid common-sense?
Vegetarianism: strange cult or healthy alternative?
Water: a cause of war
A little incident that I saw recently that shows just what's wrong with this country
The green movement: business opportunity for the 21st century
Do advertisements manipulate people?
Is the culture of East Asia different to that of America and Europe? If so, how?
Experiments on live animals
What makes a good hotel
The best make of car for an executive is ...
Privatization
Are slimming products a fraud?

List 3

Violence on television
Dogs/cats as pets
Waiting in airports: how I make the time go quickly
Love: when we're with the people we love, we get irritated by them; when we're away from them, we miss them.
If I had funds to invest in just one national stock market at the moment, the country I would choose is ...
Are the interests of shareholders the same as those of managers?
Controls on currency trading: a good idea?
Can free markets solve pollution and environmental problems?
Sunbathing: a dangerous vanity?
Smoking in public places
Clean energy: is it possible?
Why I could/couldn't survive on a desert island
My favourite museum in the world
Schools should be like companies
Marketing opportunities on the Internet
Immigration

List 4

Gun control
Managers and entrepreneurs: are they different?
The latest trends in marketing
Students should pay for their own education
Chemicals in food
Euthanasia: is it acceptable?
Legalizing soft drugs
Does a woman have to be twice as good as a man to get promotion?
Save the tiger! Save the panda! Why? We manage OK without the dinosaur.
Reducing unemployment: a freer labour market or more government intervention?
Computers and children
A management book I recently read
Entertaining budgets: can they be justified?
An unsuccessful product launch and the lessons I learned
Speed limits/seat belts/alcohol limits while driving
The cost of progress
Recycling waste material: domestic/industrial
How to learn new vocabulary



4.11

Problems, problems

Form small groups to have a discussion. Follow this sequence:

- 1 One person choose a problem from the list and explain it in your own words to the others.
- 2 Everyone think of possible solutions to the problem. Choose the best solution.
- 3 Repeat for the other people in the group.

Making suggestions

How about ... (+ *-ing*)?

Why not ... ?

It's just an idea, but why don't you ...?

Have you ever thought of ... (+ *-ing*)

I know, maybe you could ...

Agreeing

That sounds like a good idea.

That might be worth trying.

Yes, I think that would work really well
because...

Disagreeing

I'm not sure about that because ...

Don't you think a better alternative
would be ... ?

I'm afraid I don't really like that idea.

- 1 You've been feeling very tired recently, although at bedtime you can't get to sleep. You seem to have little energy for doing anything at the moment.
- 2 You have a debt of \$3000 on your VISA card. You don't have much cash at the moment.
- 3 You feel that you are a little overweight. You have tried dieting and exercise many times but each time you give up after a few weeks.
- 4 Your son has recently been caught trying to break into a car and steal the radio. You can't understand it as he is normally so well-behaved. He refuses to talk about it.
- 5 A friend of yours has just lost her job at the age of 50 due to reorganization in her company. She was a Marketing Manager, and was successful in her work. She has applied for many jobs but never even gets an answer.
- 6 You have invited your boss for dinner at your house tonight and have prepared a beautiful meat dish. Suddenly you remember that your boss is vegetarian. He/She is due to arrive in 45 minutes. What dish can you prepare to impress him/her?
- 7 You've got to buy a present for your retired aunt. You don't have much money or much time to go looking.
- 8 Your mother-in-law lives in the same block. She often visits and usually finds something to criticize.
- 9 Your job is boring, badly paid and you don't really like your colleagues. Unfortunately new jobs are hard to find these days.
- 10 You want to improve your English but you have very little time and it is impossible to attend regular classes.



What makes a good chairperson?

Worksheet

- A** Work individually. Imagine you are the chairperson in each situation below. What would your response be? Number your first and second choice each time.
- B** Have a meeting to reach a group decision on the best and second best response for each situation. Change the role of chairperson after every two items:
And now I'm going to hand over the chair to ...

- 1 You are expecting ten participants for a 9.00 am meeting. It is 9.02 and only eight people are present. The two missing people are not key participants. No one told you of any plans to be late.
 - a Begin the meeting with those present.
 - b Call the two people on their mobile phones to see if they are coming.
 - c Wait another few minutes and then begin.
- 2 The meeting has been running for 25 minutes. Some participants have not spoken, although they appear to be interested and attentive.
 - a Do nothing at the moment, but continue to monitor the situation.
 - b Ask one of the non-contributors for an opinion or reaction.
 - c Ask the non-contributors in a friendly way why they are not speaking.
- 3 As chairperson, you have introduced a topic. However, no-one wants to begin the discussion.
 - a Ask a general question to the group.
 - b Ask a general question to one person.
 - c Ask an easy, specific question to one person.
- 4 The meeting has been running for 45 minutes and half the agenda items have been covered. You notice, through non-verbal behaviour, that the interest level of the group is falling.
 - a Say you will shorten the meeting, then finish the current item and close the meeting.
 - b Suggest a five-minute break.
 - c Speak more loudly and in a more lively way.
- 5 One participant starts talking for a long time about a topic that is not on the agenda.
 - a Say in a friendly way *I feel this is a bit of a side-track*, then refocus the discussion.
 - b Thank the participant and suggest you discuss the topic at the next meeting.
 - c Thank the participant and suggest you discuss the topic at the end of the meeting if there is time.
- 6 Two people, sitting together, keep whispering to each other. It has been going on for some time.
 - a Ask them to share their discussion with the group.
 - b Ask one of them a specific question to refocus their attention.
 - c Pause at an appropriate point while you are talking and look at them. Wait until they stop.



4.13

World leaders

Business Builder
Teacher Resource Series

Worksheet

Next month the Presidents/Prime Ministers of America, Russia, China, Japan, Germany, France, the UK and the country where you are now are coming to this room to have a secret meeting about a major international crisis. The meeting will be on a Saturday and will last from 9.00am until 4.00pm. On Sunday these leaders will go on a sightseeing tour of the city where you are now with their wives/husbands. You are the organizers of the weekend. You have a budget of \$4000 to spend on preparing the room, and you must also plan the sightseeing day.

- A** Work with a partner to prepare for the meeting. Study the options below for how to spend the \$4000. Then study the schedule for the sightseeing day and think of ideas for the visits.
- B** Form a group, choose a chairperson and have a meeting.

Preparing the room	Cost	Total per item
1 Security review and report by specialist firm	800	
2 Hire of notebook PC with Internet access (per computer)	200	
3 Hire of printer, scanner, fax and photocopier	400	
4 Translator (per language – only bilingual translators available)	400	
5 Executive secretary to take notes of the meeting	400	
6 Coffee, sandwiches, biscuits	300	
7 Redecoration, flowers on the table, pictures on the walls	600	
8 Hire of temporary air-conditioning unit	200	
9 Flip chart & marker pens; place cards	200	
10 Gift (_____)	?	

Schedule for sightseeing on Sunday

9.30 - 1.00	Visit to one or two historic buildings/places of interest
1.00 - 3.00	Lunch
3.00 - 5.30	Further visit
8.00	Cultural event (theatre, opera etc.)

Agenda for the meeting

- 1 Chairperson's opening comments
- 2 Decision on how to spend the \$4000 budget
- 3 Decision on the programme for Sunday



4.14

Product launch: WOW! Clothing

Worksheet

You work for Hotspot International, a marketing consultancy. Hotspot has just won the contract to launch a new brand of clothing in your market. You will have a meeting to discuss your launch campaign.

- A** Work with a partner to prepare for the meeting. Study the background information and agenda. Discuss some ideas to present to the meeting.
- B** Form a group, choose a chairperson and have a meeting.

Background information

Client: WOW! Clothing (WOW! is a franchise)
Product: A full range of casual, mid-price clothing for both sexes
Target Market: 15-24 age group
Main Competitor: _____
Client objective: To obtain 10% market share in first year
Campaign length: Two months

Agenda

- 1 Chairperson's opening comments.
- 2 Brand image. (fun? sporty? radical and alternative? Other?)
- 3 Style of campaign. (controversial? humorous? emphasizing quality? emphasizing value for money? Other?)
- 4 Slogan to promote the brand.
- 5 Well-known personality to promote the brand. (Someone from the world of pop music? sport? How will the personality be used?)
- 6 Media mix. Decide what % of the budget will be spent on:
TV ____ Radio ____ Newspapers ____ Magazines ____ Posters ____ Sponsorship of music/sports ____
- 7 Use of chosen media.
TV: which channels? what times? what type of advert?
Radio: which stations? what times? what type of advert?
Newspapers: which ones? what type of advert?
Magazines: which ones? what type of advert?
Posters: bus-shelters? metro? large roadside sites?
Sponsorship: what type of events?
- 8 Special launch event that will get good media coverage.



4.15

A public relations problem

Worksheet

Your company sells pre-cooked meals through large supermarket chains. Last month you launched a new line with an expensive advertising campaign on the television. The launch was very successful. Yesterday some newspapers reported new research which shows that eating genetically modified soya beans may increase the risk of cancer in rats. Your new line of food uses genetically modified soya. This morning a consumer group phoned your company asking for an interview and a public statement. Your company will give a press conference tomorrow. You have been called to an urgent meeting to discuss the situation.

- A** Prepare to have a meeting. Choose your roles (you may have to combine roles). Read your own role notes.
- B** Have a meeting using the agenda below.

Role-notes

President	You will chair the meeting using the agenda below. Try to get agreement on what you need to do. Start by asking everybody in turn to describe the situation from their point of view.
Marketing Director	Should you still promote the new line or should you recall the products (take them off the market)? How can you restore confidence in your products?
Marketing Manager	Yesterday afternoon your phone didn't stop ringing – supermarket managers were calling to know if the food was safe and what action you were taking. Orders for pre-cooked food are 25% down. Other products carrying your brand name are also showing lower sales.
Finance Director	Any solution has to be justified in terms of cost. Recalling the product and launching a new line will be very expensive. A new advertising campaign or new packaging will be expensive.
Product Manager	Many other tests have shown that these genetically modified vegetables are safe. Probably there was a mistake in the experiment. Further tests may not give a clear answer. The problem is that consumer groups like to make trouble.
Public Relations Officer	You will speak at a press conference tomorrow. What will you say? How can you limit the damage to your sales and your company image?

Agenda

- 1 Chairperson's opening comments
- 2 Immediate action regarding the new line
- 3 Press conference tomorrow: what to say



4.16

Personal training needs

Worksheet

COMPETITION

Persuade your colleagues to send you on a training course

- A** Work individually. Choose a short training course that you would like to go on (see the list below for ideas). Prepare a short presentation explaining why you would benefit from going on this particular course. Use your real-life training needs to persuade your colleagues that you should go.
- B** Divide into two groups of equal size. At the end change group roles.
- Group A** Give your presentations to Group B.
- Group B** Listen carefully to each presentation and take a few notes. Ask follow-up questions and give the presenters every chance to explain their case.
- C** Each group has enough money to send just one person from the other group on a training course. Have meetings in different rooms to decide on who you would send.

Ideas for training courses

Training Course	Location and Duration	Details
Business English	UK 2 weeks	Intensive course of Business English. Contact with other students from around the world. Some free time to see the local area.
Advanced Software	California 2 weeks	Advanced training for an integrated suite of business software. Covers word-processing, spreadsheets, databases and networks. Some free time to visit California.
Outdoor Training	Lake District, NW England 2 weeks	Development of teamwork, self-confidence, ability to take decisions under stress – and a time to reflect. Physically demanding but within the capabilities of the average person.
Job Rotation	In-Company	You spend one month in every department of your company to learn about every aspect of the business.
Junior Board	In-Company	You work with other middle managers on a 'junior' Board of Directors. You are given the opportunity for top-level analysis and policy making.
Other (your idea)		

4.17

Reducing costs

You work for a medium-sized manufacturing company. You make high-quality office furniture. Foreign competitors have recently entered your market. You must reduce costs urgently to make your company more competitive. You have to make savings of 50 currency units. A firm of consultants has suggested some possible savings in a report which is summarized below.

- A** Study the consultants' recommendations.
- B** Prepare to have a meeting. Choose which department/s you will represent (you may have to combine roles) and read your own role-notes. There will be a neutral President.
- C** Have a meeting to decide how to reduce your costs by 50 currency units. Balance the desire to protect your own department with the need to assist the company.

Consultants' recommendations

Department	Staff	Estimated savings (units)
Production and Operating	30	• better quality control to reduce waste and defects10
		• save energy5
		• better maintenance of machines5
		• freeze investment in new equipment10
		• reduce inventories (stocks) of finished goods10
Marketing	6	• reduce advertising budget15
		• reduce market research into new product ideas5
Sales	12	• reduce entertaining and travel costs10
Human Resources	2	• increase salaries by 2% less than the rate of inflation15
		• cut staff in all departments5 units per person
		• change staff cars every four years instead of every two years ..10
		• reduce training budget5
Accounts	6	• reduce receivables (money owed by customers)10
		• pay suppliers later10
		• delay upgrade of computers5
		• reduce dividend to shareholders5

Role-notes

President	You are neutral and will chair the meeting. Start by asking everybody in turn to describe the situation from their point of view.
Production and Operating	You think the suggested savings for quality control and reducing inventories are exaggerated.
Marketing	Reducing the advertising budget won't help. In fact it will make the situation worse.
Sales	It is vital to keep good relationships with customers, and your sales team needs to take them out to lunch occasionally.
Human Resources	If you give a small salary increase you risk losing skilled workers. The training budget is an investment for the future.
Accounts	You think the figures for improving cash-flow are exaggerated. You want to keep the good relationship you have with suppliers.

4.18

Appraisal meeting

Business Builder
Teacher Resource Series

Worksheet

Student A: Employee

You are going to have an appraisal interview with your line manager. These meetings are standard practice in your company. In the meeting you should cover the points below.

Problem in the team. One of your colleagues, Bill, is very difficult to work with. He is not a good team member and his behaviour is affecting your whole department. You think your manager should talk to Bill and possibly move him to another department.

Promotion. Find out about opportunities for promotion.

Salary increase for next year. Negotiate your salary increase for next year. You would like 4% above the rate of inflation. Your company has a policy of rewarding performance and your department is doing well at the moment.

Time-keeping. You live a long way from your work and it's sometimes difficult to arrive on time in the morning. You would like to start and finish half an hour later than everyone else.

Personal development. Your manager will ask you these questions. Answer honestly, based on your real-life job.

- What do you see as your strengths and weaknesses?
- Have you any ideas how you can develop yourself as a team member?
- How could your job or the system be improved?



Student B: Line manager

You are going to have an appraisal interview with an employee (one of your best workers). These meetings are standard practice in your company. In the meeting you should cover the points below.

Problem in the team. A few weeks ago this employee had an argument with another team member, Bill. It seems that both sides were at fault. Relations between them have been difficult since then. Mention this in the meeting, but very tactfully (be careful not to offend).

Promotion. Opportunities for promotion are very limited at the moment. Your company has just dismissed a lot of people and there are no vacant posts. However, no more dismissals are planned and you can reassure this employee that his/her job is safe.

Salary increase for next year. Negotiate this employee's salary increase for next year. The economic climate is still difficult and you can't offer very much – maybe two percentage points above inflation. Listen to his/her case and negotiate what you think is a reasonable increase.

Time-keeping. Occasionally this employee is late for work. This gives a bad example to the other staff. Last Monday morning, for example, this employee was very late and gave no excuse.

Personal development. Ask the employee these questions. He/she will answer based on his/her real-life job.

- What do you see as your strengths and weaknesses?
- Have you any ideas how you can develop yourself as a team member?
- How could your job or the system be improved?



4.19

Economic predictions

Worksheet

You have been asked to make predictions about the economy of one country where you all do business. This information is needed to help your companies plan their operations and make investment decisions. Decide which country you are going to discuss: _____

- A** Work with a partner. Study the list of economic and financial indicators below. What do you think the situation will be 12 months from now? Make a prediction (percentage increase/decrease) for each indicator and write the figure in the 'first guess' column. If you feel that you don't have sufficient information, leave a blank and move on.
- B** Form a group, choose a chairperson, and have a meeting to reach a group decision on your predictions.

Economic Indicators	12 months from now (% +/-)	
	First guess	Group decision
Gross domestic product (GDP)		
Inflation (consumer prices)		
Consumer spending (retail sales)		
Government spending		
Salaries (earnings)		
Unemployment		
Imports		
Exports		

Financial Indicators	12 months from now (% +/-)	
	First guess	Group decision
Interest rates		
Value of stock market		
Currency unit / dollar, euro, yen (choose which)		
House prices		



4.20

Bad news!

Bad news! This building is not available for the next day of the course. You will have to find somewhere else to have the class for just one day. Your teacher is too busy to help but can give a normal lesson in the new place. You will have to pay any extra costs yourselves. Sorry!

- A** Choose a chairperson. He/She should draw a large grid on the board like the one below. Everyone else work individually and think of two or three ideas for where to have the class. Prepare some arguments. Be specific, for example instead of saying 'in a café', say which café.
- B** Read through stages 1–7 of a formal decision-making process shown below. This is a standard process often used for making complicated decisions. Then use this process to have a meeting to decide where to have your lesson on the next day of the course.

Criteria	weight	Café ?					
1 Cost	x?						
2							
3							
4							
5							

Stages of a formal decision-making process

- 1 Write up all your ideas on a separate part of the board. Brainstorm some more. Then choose the good ones and write them across the top of the grid (Café ? etc.). Don't try to decide which is the best yet.
- 2 Decide which criteria you will use to help choose between the different ideas (cost? noise? etc.). Write them under 'Criteria'.
- 3 Discuss each idea in relation to 'Cost'. Fill in the first row of the grid using a simple three-point system: write 3 for the best alternative/s (in this case the cheapest one/s), 2 for the next best and 1 for the worst (in this case the most expensive).
- 4 Repeat for the other criteria. Fill in the remaining rows.
- 5 Decide how important each criterion is. This is its weight. Use a simple three-point system: write x3 (times three) for the most important criteria, x2 for the next most important and x1 for the least important.
- 6 Multiply each number in the grid by the weight, then cross out the old number and put the new number in its place.
- 7 Add the numbers in each column and put the totals at the bottom. The idea with the highest total is the best choice.



Dialogue building: discussion

Write a short dialogue using the model below.

Person B

◀▶ Ask a question

◀▶ Give an opinion and develop your argument

◀▶ Check you understand/Ask for clarification

◀▶ Agree and develop your argument

◀▶ Reply

[illegible]

Worksheet

Chairperson

- ### Person B

- ### Person C

- 7 Interrupt/Ask a question
9 Disagree

-
- This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue or grey ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.